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Module Name	Business Project
Programme Name	
Student Reference Number (SRN)	
Assessment Title	Business Consultancy Project – Addressing Sustainability Pressure and Supply Chain Transparency at Nike Inc.

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Executive Summary

Nike Inc. is a global sportswear leader with sales of more than US$52 billion and operations spanning 170 countries. Its complicated value chain comprises thousands of suppliers that produce footwear, apparel and equipment, and its iconic brand creates consumer loyalty and economic strength. But pressure on Nike's environmental footprint, Scope 3 emissions and labour standards in its extended supply chain is mounting among stakeholders, including regulators, investors, customers and non-government organisations (NGOs). Evidence from Nike's FY2024 sustainability data shows that 94 % of facilities in the company's extended supply chain met foundational health, safety and environmental standards, with the company aiming for 100 % compliance by FY2025. Nike also reports high renewable-electricity use – 96 % of its owned or operated facilities ran on renewable power in FY2024 – and 96 % of energy used in 2023 came from renewable sources. These results show improvement, though external evaluations indicate serious flaws. Independent analysis reports incomplete Scope 3 emissions reporting, lack of access to sustainable materials at scale and transparency on waste. NGOs note that former garment workers in Cambodia and Thailand are still owed US$2.2 million in severance pay after supplier factory closures and claim that Nike has not provided adequate remediation. Shareholders have acted by submitting shareholder resolutions requiring Nike to sign binding labour agreements; the Norwegian sovereign wealth fund publicly endorsed similar resolutions. The administration of Nike has discredited these resolutions, citing that there are already codes of conduct and supplier audits, but opponents claim that voluntary compliance tools are toothless. Meanwhile, the sportswear industry is evolving fast. Global sportswear sales rose 3.2 % in 2024 to US$430 billion, with emerging markets driving growth; Asia-Pacific and Middle East–Africa are forecast to experience compound annual growth rates (CAGR) of 4.4 % and 7.1 %, respectively. Consumers are increasingly preferring sustainable and recycled product materials and technologies that allow traceable supply chains. Rival brands like Adidas, Lululemon and Chinese Li-Ning and Anta are capturing market share, and ESG-aware investors are reviewing the climate and labour performance of companies. The consultancy project explores the impact of sustainability pressure and supply-chain transparency issues on the strategic position of Nike, as well as evaluates the existing practices of the company to PESTLE, Five Forces, and SWOT, analyses stakeholder expectations, and suggests feasible

recommendations. The study is based on secondary research like Nike sustainability reports, other ESG studies, industry surveys and media research. The report still finds that even though Nike has achieved in renewable energy and product innovation, the company needs more rapid Scope 3 emissions cuts, sustainable material sourcing, state-of-the-art digital transparency, and worker rights through binding agreements. These recommendations would help Nike to improve its brand reputation, investor confidence and competitive advantage in the long term.

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1 Introduction

Global fashion and sportswear have become associated with sustainability. The industry contributes to the world's carbon output by about 10% and is under increased pressure regarding the use of resources, waste and labour conditions. Customers are becoming more insistent on ethical goods and information on the production of clothes. The regulators and investors are implementing tougher criteria on environmental, social and governance (ESG) performances, and the new digital technologies facilitate supply-chain transparency. It is against this background that Nike Inc., a sportswear manufacturer based in 1964 in Oregon, the USA, stands at the top of its industry yet has severe sustainability issues. The company has an extensive global supply chain with hundreds of subcontract manufacturers in Asia, Latin America and Europe. Its reputation is dented by recent scandals of poor pay, purported labour malpractices and mysterious subcontracting. NGOs and investor advocacy groups have urged Nike to enter into binding agreements that will improve working conditions in the supplier factories. Meanwhile, Nike has introduced programmes like its Move to Zero programme, where it targets zero carbon emissions and zero waste, and claims high renewable electricity consumption. This report will look at how the issues of sustainability pressure and supply-chain transparency affect the strategic position of Nike and how it can improve them. It is based on the structure of the consultancy brief: a company overview, problem definition, stakeholder analysis, data analysis through the PESTLE and Porter's Five Forces and SWOT model, strategic suggestions, and a reflection on the employability skills acquired.

2 Company / Client Overview

Nike Inc. originated as Blue Ribbon Sports in 1964 and changed its name to Nike in 1971 (Hou, 2023). Headquartered in Beaverton, Oregon, the company has grown into the world’s largest supplier of athletic footwear and apparel, employing more than 80 000 people and generating revenues of roughly US$52 billion.

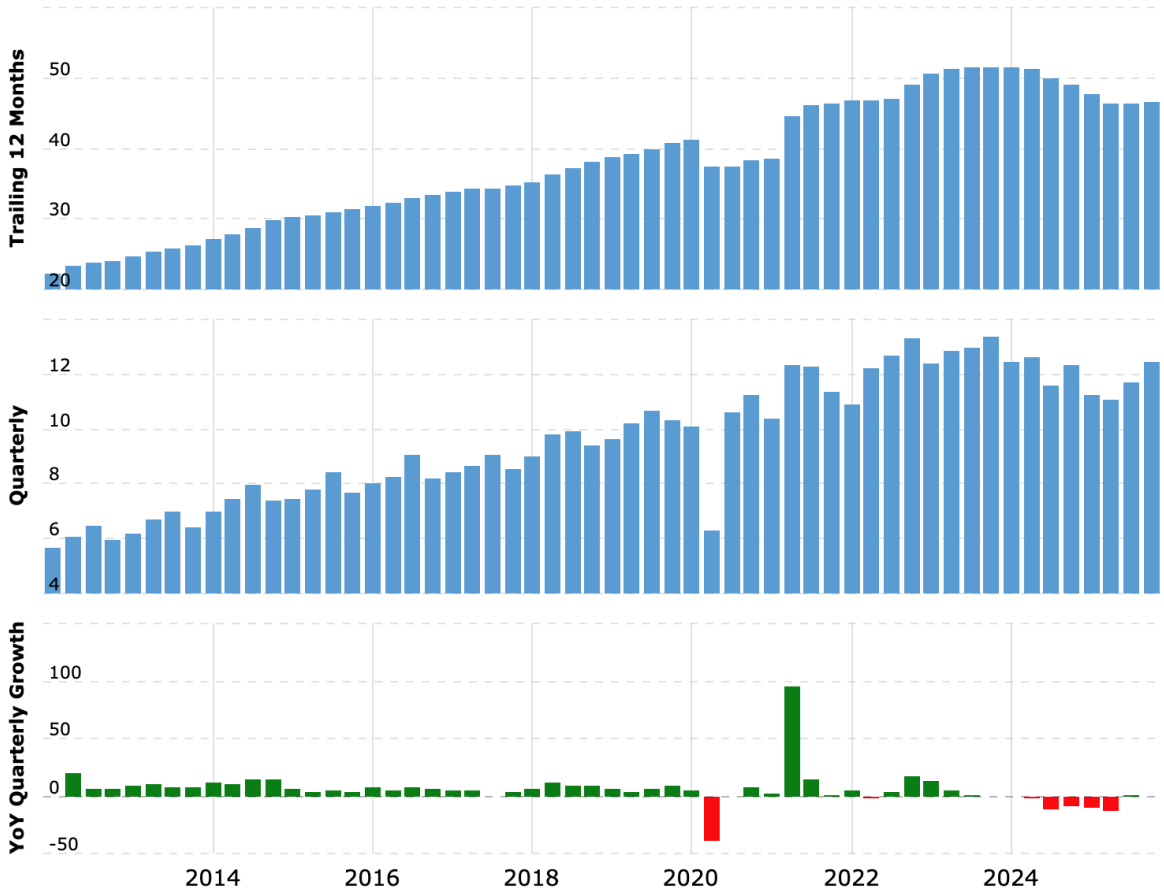


Figure 1: NIKE Revenue 2012-2025 | NKE Source: (Macrotrends, 2025)

Its product portfolio includes footwear (more than 60 % of revenue), apparel, equipment and accessories under the Nike, Jordan and Converse brands. The company sells worldwide by a combination of wholesale sales, direct-to-customer outlets and online stores. Nike's manufacturing model relies on a network of contract suppliers, mainly in Asia (Vietnam, China, Indonesia, India, Pakistan, and Cambodia), with a few in Latin America and Europe. The model of outsourcing offers flexibility and cost efficiency but poses challenges in enforcing labour standards, environmental practices, and supplier transparency. Sportswear is a very competitive industry. Market research indicates that global sportswear sales grew by 3.2% in 2025 to US$399.4 billion and are expected to reach US$890.4 billion by 2033, representing a compound annual growth rate of 3.3%.

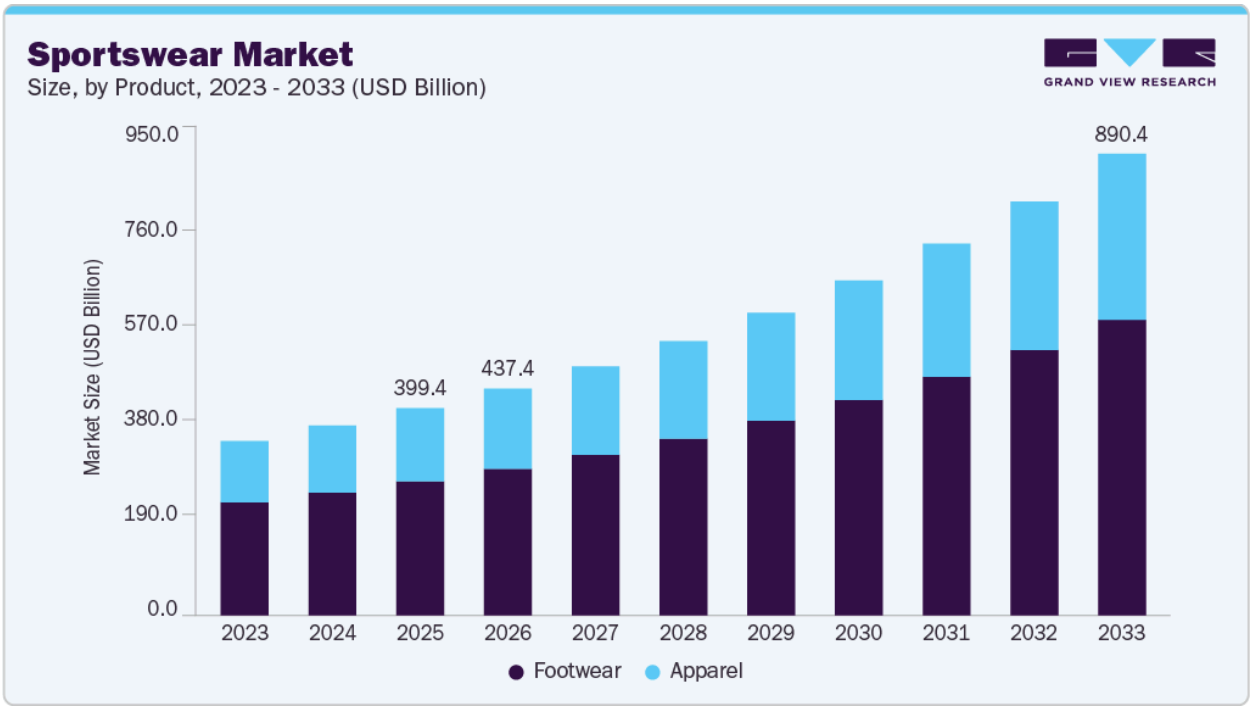


Figure 2: Global Sportswear Market Source: (Grand View Research, 2024)

Emerging markets, particularly in the Asia-Pacific and Middle East-Africa, show the greatest growth, as demand is fuelled by increasing urbanisation, health awareness, and rising middle-class populations. While Nike remains the market leader with a 12.7% share, competitors such as Adidas, Puma, Under Armour, Lululemon, and fast-growing Chinese brands Li-Ning and Anta are gaining ground. Trends in the industry in 2025 include sustainable and environmentally responsible fabrics, connected activewear, inclusive sizes and multi-design. Online retail and direct-to-consumer platforms are taking an increasing share of sales (Bardelli and Cavenaghi, 2025). In such a scenario, Nike's future competitiveness will rest on how it synchronises product innovation and supply-chain operations with sustainability expectations, retains brand differentiation, and responds to changing consumer behaviours.

3 Problem Definition / Aim / Purpose / Consultancy Focus

3.1 Problem Statement

The Nike supply chain network covers hundreds of manufacturing partners worldwide.

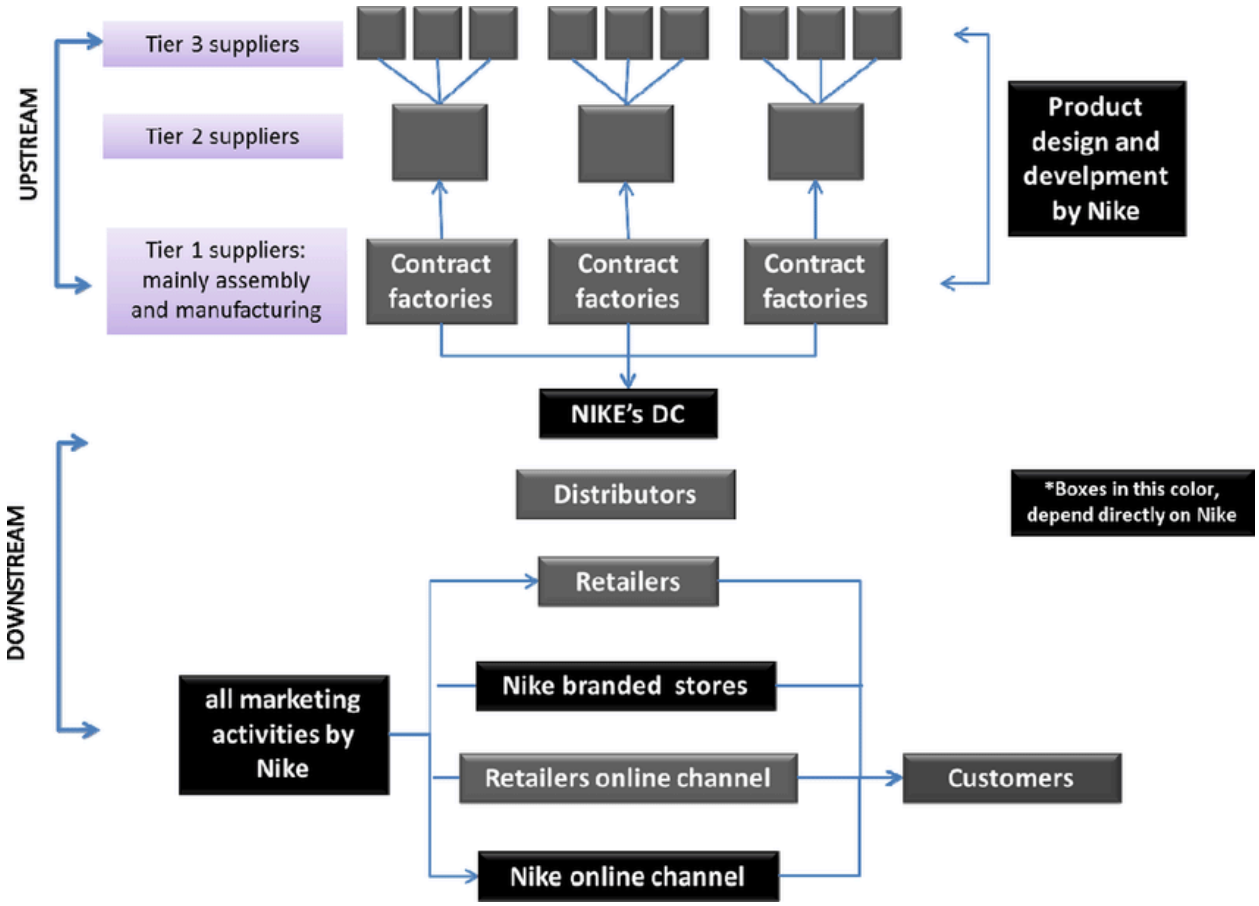


Figure 3: Nike supply chain Network Source: (Castorena and Monroy, 2020)

This is extremely difficult to oversee labour standards, environmental stewardship, and transparency. NGO and media investigations have found instances of wage theft and non-payment of severance at factories of Cambodian and Thai suppliers. The accusations of compulsory overtime and subcontracting contribute to reputational risk. Even though Nike's code of conduct forbids child labour and forced labour, critics claim that the audit regimes do not tend to identify abuses. Concurrently, more than 90 % of Nike's carbon footprint comes from its supply chain (Oviedo, 2022). Achieving transparency and sustainability in such a decentralised value chain is therefore the fundamental issue in this consultancy project.

3.2 Project Aim

This consultancy project will assess Nike's sustainability pressures and supply-chain transparency issues, with a view to advising on strategic solutions to improve ethical sourcing,

minimise environmental impact, and increase stakeholder trust. Using frameworks such as PESTLE, Porter's Five Forces, and SWOT, the project will evaluate the impact of external forces (political, economic, social, technological, legal, and environmental) and competition on Nike's capacity to practise responsible supply-chain operations (Li, 2023). It will also examine internal governance, operational and innovation strengths and weaknesses. The general aim is to develop evidence-based principles to help achieve long-term competitiveness and fulfil the expectations of investors, consumers and regulators.

3.3 Purpose of the Report

This report performs three functions: first, it offers a rigorous, data-driven examination of Nike's data transparency and sustainability activities based on existing information. Second, to pinpoint discrepancies between Nike's official statements and stakeholder demands, based on the independent ESG ratings, media findings and market trends (Karim, 2025). Third, to make concrete recommendations that Nike can take to ensure sustainable sourcing, reduce Scope 3 emissions, embrace digital traceability tools, and enhance workers' rights. This report presents an expert consultancy that will guide Nike's strategic decision-making and inform investors and regulators interested in ESG performance (Soltanisehat and Jestratijevic, 2026).

3.4 Consultancy Focus

The consultancy focuses on corporate sustainability strategy and supply chain management. In particular, the project assesses the effects of environmental goals, supply-chain transparency, and labour rights on Nike's strategic environment. It examines how Nike (via Move to Zero, Supply Chain Sustainability Index and Responsible Supply Chain programmes) aligns with external expectations (Sailaubayeva, 2023). The report analyses industry competitiveness, stakeholder power and internal capabilities by incorporating PESTLE, Porter's Five Forces analysis and SWOT. It aims to provide strategic advice on sustainable material sourcing, digital transparency solutions (such as blockchain and product passports), supplier interactions, and governance frameworks that enhance ethical conduct and resilience.

4 Stakeholder Analysis

The stakeholders have varying power and interests in the success of the sustainability initiatives of Nike. The Matrix developed by Mendelow is used to analyse the key stakeholders and potential conflicts.

Internal stakeholders

Senior management and board: Nike has an overall strategic orientation, and it focuses on tracking ESG objectives. Top executives must trade off profitability, brand development and investments in sustainability programmes (Asghar, 2023). They are powerful and interesting because success will rely on the financial performance and corporate image.

Employees: Nike has a workforce in its design, marketing, manufacturing oversight, distribution and retail. Employees require fair treatment and safe working conditions. Their bargaining power is mediocre, but their sustainability is high.

Shareholders: Institutional investors are highly powerful and increasingly outspoken on ESG matters. A resolution introduced by sovereign wealth fund and other investors in Norway demanded additional supply-chain labour standards and transparency (Dahlan, Lastra and Rochette, 2022). Long-term value and risk reduction are needed by high-interest shareholders.

External stakeholders

Consumers: Clients are demanding eco-products. Surveys on the trend of sportswear show that there is an increase in demand regarding recycled fabrics, organic cotton and biodegradable fabrics. The buyers have moderate buying power and social media activism and are interested in ethical sourcing.

Non-governmental organisations (NGOs) and labour advocacy groups, such as the Clean Clothes Campaign, the Worker Rights Consortium, and others, focus on the rights of garment workers (Li and Hu, 2022). They mobilise campaigns that influence brand reputation and highlight unpaid wages and labour rights violations, such as the US$2.2 million owed to workers at Cambodian and Thai suppliers.

Regulators and policymakers: The governments are implementing stricter due diligence and sustainability reporting laws. The European Union Corporate Sustainability Due Diligence Directive will force companies to outline and eradicate human-rights impacts in their supply chains (Sinnig and Zetzsche, 2025). The concerns about climate and labour are increasing, and regulators are stronger than ever.

Suppliers: Nike has Tier one and Tier two suppliers who manufacture footwear and apparel on a contractual basis. Where alternative suppliers are limited, they are relatively strong and are under pressure to adhere to the directives of the Code of Conduct and Code Leadership established by Nike. Outsourcing can bring about invisible labour issues.

Investors and analysts: ESG investors keep an eye on Nike in terms of carbon emissions and labour rights (Kamal, 2025). Over 70 institutional investors controlling US$4 trillion signed a letter urging Nike to pay outstanding wages. Analysts also analyse competitive positioning; the dwindling ESG ratings could put off capital.

Communities and activists: Communities, where manufacturing plants are located, environmental pollution, stability in the work environment and safety of the workers are the significant concerns. They are moderately powerful and can increase their power by joining alliances with NGOs.

Mendelow's Matrix

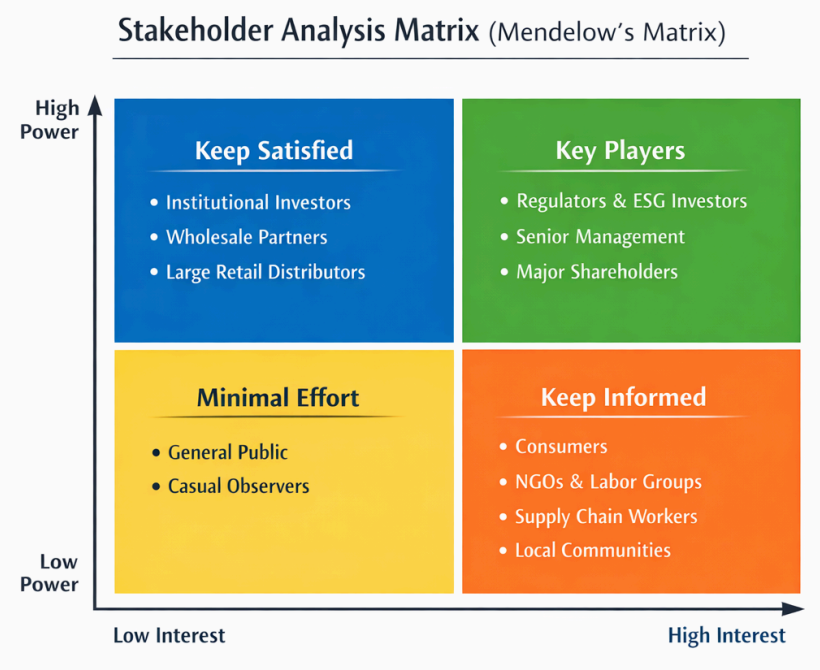


Figure 4: Stakeholder Matrix Source: Self-Created

High-power high-interest stakeholders are the senior management, key shareholders, regulators, and NGOs. Institutional investors are the high-power-low-interest parties, who are mostly interested in financial returns. Consumers are low-power, high-interest parties that indirectly affect reputation but may have an impact (Hasan, 2024). The ordinary citizens are weak and indifferent. Controversies arise in the case of profit-seeking investors and NGOs insisting on a binding labour agreement or failure of suppliers to embrace stricter environmental rules. An effective way of communication and stakeholder expectations involvement in the strategy is required.

5 Data Analysis & Framework Application

5.1 PESTLE Analysis

The PESTLE framework analyses the external environment affecting Nike.

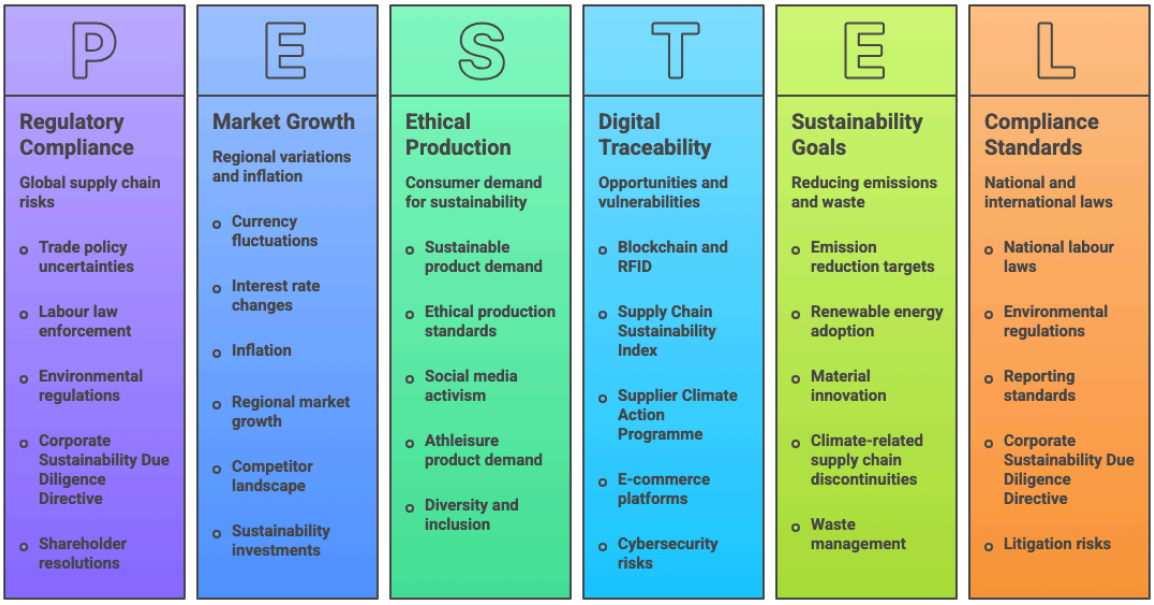


Figure 5: Nike PESTEL Analysis Source: Self-Created

Political: Nike is at risk of various regulatory environments due to the utilisation of global supply chains. The trade policies, labour laws and environmental regulations affect the cost of production and the flexibility of operation. There are uncertainties in the U.S.China trade tensions, and the tariffs put on the imports of Vietnam and India (Rahmadi and Yandri, 2025). The new Corporate Sustainability Due Diligence Directive proposed by the European Union will oblige large enterprises to discover the risks of human rights and environmental waste in their value chains, which will make compliance more expensive. Nike has a heavy dependence on subcontracting, which might increase the political pressure when the government calls for enforceable standards. Debates in the civil society have led to lawmaking vehicles like the Fashion Sustainability and Social Accountability Act in New York that would enforce disclosures in the supply chain. Rising political pressure can be seen in shareholder resolutions that request workers to take social responsibility (Piccolo, 2024).

Economic: Macroeconomic influences, including currency changes, interest rates and inflation, have an impact on production costs and consumption spending. Although the global sportswear market is forecast to grow at a 3.3 % CAGR between 2024 and 2029, regional growth varies. Asia-Pacific and Middle East–Africa will experience faster expansion (4.4 % and 7.1 % CAGR) as urbanisation and health awareness increase, whereas mature Western markets may stagnate.

The competitors that Nike has to work with include both old industry rivals (Adidas, Puma, Lululemon) and new Chinese brands such as Li-Ning and Anta. Economic headwinds such as inflation can influence discretionary spending; nevertheless, strong demand for athleisure and the shift to e-commerce (online sportswear spending grew 6.8 % in 2024) create growth opportunities (Zhu, 2022). Sustainability investments: renewable energy, circular design and digital traceability have more capital requirements and could lower the costs over time due to efficiency.

Social: The trends are towards more sustainable products and ethical production. The analysis of sportswear trends shows an increased interest in eco-friendly materials (recycled polyester, organic cotton, biodegradable products) and non-discriminatory sizes (Vezzoli et al., 2022). The younger generation would favour brands that correspond with their ideals and would boycott organisations that were involved in labour abuses. Social media gives activism a voice, such as during campaigns of unpaid labourers in Cambodia and Thailand. Demand in athleisure products is also propelled by cultural shifts in favour of health, fitness and wellbeing. Nike's marketing must address these values while promoting diversity and inclusion; for example, the company reports that 41 % of its global workforce and 44 % of leadership roles are held by racial and ethnic minorities or women.

Technological: Digital technologies provide chances to trace and consumer engagement. Product passports that cater to materials and labour conditions can be built using blockchain and RFID technologies, allowing customers to verify ethical sourcing (Vahidi et al., 2024). The Supply Chain Sustainability Index (SCSI) of Nike is used to assess logistics providers, and its Supplier Climate Action Programme (SCAP) collaborates with factory partners in Vietnam and Indonesia to switch to renewable energy. The shift to online shopping platforms and analytics enables Nike to customise products and predict demand. Nevertheless, swift changes in technology necessitate investing in cybersecurity and can potentially reveal vulnerabilities in the supply chain.

Legal: Nike should ensure that they abide by national labour laws, environmental regulations and reporting standards. Its Code of Conduct forbids child labour and requires workers to be 16 or above the legal age. This firm prohibits forced labour and demands that its suppliers comply with recruitment policies that do not allow workers to pay fees. However, audit-based

enforcement and voluntary compliance mechanisms have been criticised as weak. Legal liability due to supply-chain abuses will grow as a result of pending legislation (e.g., the Corporate Sustainability Due Diligence Directive of the EU) (Ventura, 2023). Risks in litigation, such as stealing wages and inability to pay severance, have been mentioned as NGOs seek compensation for 5,000 workers.

Environmental: Nike focuses on environmental sustainability. The company aims to cut Scope 1 and 2 emissions by 65 % and Scope 3 emissions by 30 % by 2030 and achieve net-zero emissions by 2050. It reports that 96 % of its owned or operated facilities use renewable electricity and has reduced air freight by 80 % since 2020. Nike invests in material innovations such as Flyleather and recycled polyester; nearly 80 % of products are made from recycled materials. Among environmental risks, there are climate-related supply-chain discontinuities, resource shortages, and carbon reduction requirements. Disposing of the products also presents a waste dilemma; opponents accuse Nike of having incomplete data related to waste handling. These risks can be addressed through circular business models and product refurbishment services (Jensen, 2025).

5.2 Porter's Five Forces

Competitive rivalry (high): The sportswear market is highly competitive. Nike has international competitors like Adidas, Puma, Under Armour and Lululemon, and blistering growth among Chinese brands Li-Ning and Anta. The innovation cycles in product and fashion are rapid, which calls on firms to keep introducing fresh designs and technology. Competition on price is average, yet brand recognition and marketing expenditure stimulate loyalty. ESG performance is becoming a differentiator; firms that are not able to address the needs of sustainability risk losing customers and investors (Giannetti et al., 2022). Poor social performance can destroy competitive advantage, as exemplified by investor downgrades of the Nike ESG rating and shareholder resolutions.

Threat of new competitors (moderate): Obstacles to entry are a large amount of capital to lead the design, to market, distribute and sponsor. Established brands have the advantages of scale, brand recognition, and large retail networks. Nevertheless, digital platforms and direct-to-consumer models decrease entry costs. Newer companies that use social media and

focus on niche sustainable offerings can appeal to new customers who place emphasis on sustainable and ethical-oriented decisions (Mahamud and Sharif, 2025). Sustainability promotion regulatory initiatives can support entry by players with responsible business-built-ins. Growth of local brands in young markets is a testimony that it can enter, especially through focused marketing and retailing online.

Bargaining power of suppliers (high): Nike uses contract manufacturers to supply. In Vietnam, Indonesia, Cambodia, Pakistan and China, suppliers can have high bargaining power because of demand in the industry and local labour resources. Interruptions like the COVID-19 pandemic and geopolitical conflicts have the potential to lower production capacity and costs. Consolidation of suppliers can enable large factory groups to negotiate favourable terms. To counter this influence, Nike relies on the Manufacturing Index and Supply Chain Sustainability Index to assess suppliers by cost, quality, delivery and sustainability (Xu and Amaeshi, 2023). It also opens investments in material innovations and vertical integration by producing experiments in manufacturing, such as Flyknit, to weaken reliance. Nonetheless, claims concerning wage theft and unfavourable working conditions demonstrate that supplier relations are sophisticated and perilous.

Power of buyers (medium and growing): Customers and individual consumers, both wholesale and final, are price sensitive and can buy many brands. E-commerce allows consumers to compare products easily and change loyalties. The rising consumer consciousness of sustainability and labour rights enhances their bargaining power. Boycotts may occur because of negative publicity of unpaid wages or environmental damage (Elshaer et al., 2025). Influencers and athletes are also involved in demand shaping. Nike has therefore to ensure that its products are ethically aligned to keep customers and to charge a premium.

Threat to substitute (moderate): Substitutes are casual wear, generic athletic clothing and local brands. Non-branded sportswear can also be sold at a flat rate, which attracts cost-conscious buyers. The depreciation of the traditional athletic wear might be caused by lifestyle adjustments, e.g., outdoor activities or fitness through digital devices (Bisht et al., 2025). Home fitness equipment and virtual training may replace apparel expenditures as technological alternatives.

Nevertheless, brand recognition, innovation (e.g., smart fabrics, recycled materials) and endorsements can distinguish the offer of Nike.

5.3 SWOT Analysis

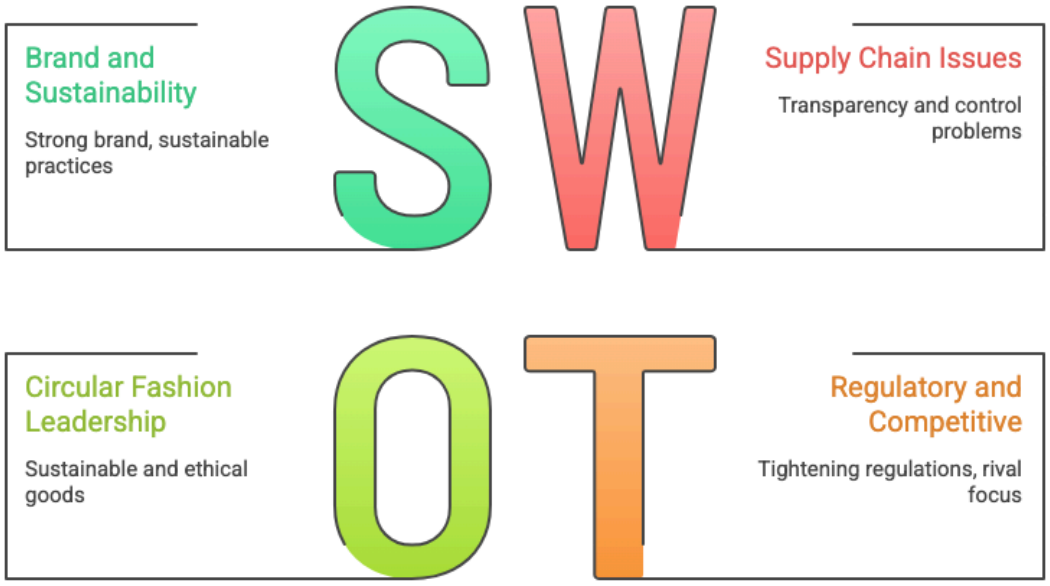


Figure 6: Nike SWOT Analysis Source: Self-Created

Strengths: Nike enjoys a strong worldwide brand and market dominance. Its shrewd marketing, endorsement by athletes, and product innovation generate strong brand loyalty. Financially, Nike remains profitable; despite sales declines in 2025 due to tariffs and competition, the company generated US$11.1 billion in Q4 2025 revenue and returned over US$1 billion to shareholders through dividends and buybacks. Nike has made significant progress in renewable energy and carbon reduction; by 2023, 96 % of the energy used in its operations was renewable. Its material innovations, such as Flyleather and recycled polyester, reduce carbon emissions by up to 80 % compared with conventional materials. Long-term sustainability goals are supported by the Move to Zero programme and Supplier Climate Action Programme of the company (Erb et al., 2022).

Weaknesses: Nike has an elaborate supply chain that poses both transparency and control issues. More than 90 % of its carbon footprint derives from Scope 3 emissions associated with suppliers and materials (Schmidt, Nill and Scholz, 2022). Voluntary supplier audits and codes of conduct

have been criticised for not detecting wage theft and labour abuses. Unpaid workers in Cambodia and Thailand are still owed US$2.2 million. Shareholder pressure points to inadequate reaction to human rights claims, and a decline in ESG ratings harms reputation. Nike concentrates on its product lines, centred mainly on footwear, which makes it sensitive to fashion changes and competition. Recent declines in market share (from 14.2 % to 12.7 % in 2025) reflect competitive pressure.

Opportunities: The increasing popularity of sustainable and ethical goods provides Nike with opportunities to become a leader in the field of circular fashion and digital transparency. Customers are interested in environmentally friendly fabrics, and this gives an opportunity to increase the presence of recycled options and biodegradable materials. Supply-chain traceability can be improved using digital technologies (blockchain, QR-coded product passports), so consumers can check the material sources and labour standards (Al Zohbi, 2025). Rising markets with great CAGRs create growth opportunities; by partnering with local suppliers and investing in region-specific products, growth can be tapped. The shift to online retail, with 6.8 % growth in sportswear e-commerce in 2024, encourages further direct-to-consumer expansion and data-driven product design.

Threats: Tightening of regulations on human rights and environmental reporting practices creates compliance expenses and introduces liability to Nike. Laws like the EU Corporate Sustainability Due Diligence Directive will involve wider monitoring. Rivals who focus on sustainability may strip away the market share unless Nike enhances transparency. Brand equity is threatened by activist campaigns and negative media publicity concerning unpaid wages and poor working conditions. Supply chains can be derailed by geopolitical risks (trade wars, political instability). Such macro-economic headwinds as inflation can lower consumer buying power and raise production expenses.

6 Recommendations and Conclusion

Recommendation 1: Expand Sustainable Materials and Circular Economy

Nike should expedite the transition to more environmentally preferred materials and circular business models. It should increase the use of recycled polyester, organic cotton and other

bio-based materials, targeting more than 60 % environmentally preferred content by 2030 and reporting progress. Simultaneously, Nike must expand programmes like Reuse-A-Shoe, refurbishment product lines and product take-back plans to encourage longevity, wearability, and recyclability (Hu, 2025). Circular design and material innovation will minimise waste and emissions, fulfil consumer expectations and ensure long-term profitability.

Recommendation 2: Implement Digital Transparency Technologies

Nike needs to implement digital options that offer real-time tracing of raw materials to complete products. The blockchain technology, IoT sensors, and QR codes can capture provenance of materials and working conditions, allowing customers to validate the recycled materials, labour conditions, and compliance in factories (Borandag, 2023). Piloting digital product passports on high-volume products such as Air Jordan sneakers would prove viability and attract customers. Partnerships with technology suppliers and industry groups like the Open Footwear Foundation can establish standards and cost-sharing. Combining the current Supply Chain Sustainability Index with end-to-end traceability would foster trust, promote proper Scope 3 emissions reporting and regulatory adherence. Implementation comes at a cost and involves supplier training, but among its advantages is strong brand credibility and supply-Chain resilience.

Recommendation 3: Strengthen Worker Rights through Binding Agreements

Even voluntary codes of conduct and audits have not been effective in safeguarding workers against wage theft and exploitation. It is thus high time for Nike to become a signatory to binding worker-rights treaties like the Pakistan Accord to implement health and safety principles and to offer vibrant grievance channels. Becoming a member would put Nike with others like Adidas and Puma, who have already signed such agreements. Formal mechanisms provide enforceable remedial options, establish transparent grievance avenues and send a powerful message to investors and NGOs. Nike must partner with labour unions, NGOs and suppliers to create Worker-Driven Social Responsibility programmes and test them in nations with unpaid wages (Oviedo, 2022). Remediation plans should entail workers' compensation in the form of severance and transparency in reporting investigations. Being a leader in worker rights will restore confidence and mitigate ESG risks.

Recommendation 4: Enhance Stakeholder Engagement and ESG Reporting

Nike needs to consider involving additional stakeholders such as shareholders, NGOs, workers, and communities. Open reporting of suppliers' lists, as well as periodic reporting on human-rights and environmental goals, will enhance credibility. Reporting must conform to standards like GRI and SASB and answer criticisms of partial Scope 3 emissions reporting and waste disposal. Frequent discussions with shareholders, NGOs and worker representatives may reveal emerging problems and develop solutions together (Ansell, Srensen and Torfing, 2022). Involvement in policymaking can influence the emergence of due diligence laws and make Nike's voice heard. Investor activism would decrease with detailed reporting on wage restitution and remedial measures, renewed human-rights risk assessment, and supplier prioritisation criteria. Active communication of difficulties and developments will assist in restoring investor confidence and fulfilling emerging regulatory standards.

Conclusion

This consulting engagement assessed Nike on sustainability pressures and supply-chain transparency using a strategic approach. The analyses showed that Nike has made significant advancements with regard to renewable energy, material innovation, and the establishment of emission reduction targets. The company sources 96 % of electricity for its operations from renewable sources and aims to cut Scope 1 and 2 emissions by 65 % and Scope 3 emissions by 30 % by 2030. Its Move to Zero initiative has resulted in nearly 80 % of products being made from recycled materials. Nonetheless, there are still considerable gaps. More than 90 % of Nike’s carbon footprint comes from its supply chain, where transparency is limited. Issues of unpaid wages and labour rights abuses at supplier factories have elicited investor activism and NGO efforts. Voluntary audit systems have not been effective in curbing abuse. Competitors are capturing market share and focusing on sustainability, and legislation is tightening. The recommendations expressed can be implemented (scaling up sustainable materials and circular systems, rolling out digital traceability systems, becoming part of binding worker-rights agreements and enhancing stakeholder involvement and ESG reporting) to make Nike a leader in responsible sportswear. Such measures will not only offset reputational and legal risks but also

add value by gratifying consumer preferences, enabling better investor relations and a competitive edge in an ever-greener, sustainability-driven market.

These insights are particularly vital.

7 Reflection on Employability

The completion of this consultancy project has improved various employability skills**. Research and analytical capabilities:** Comprehensive analysis of scholarly articles, sustainability reports, third-party industry analysis and media investigations made it possible to collect and combine a variety of data types. The ability to derive information about tricky documents, such as Nike FY24 Sustainability Data, was enhanced by critical reading and attentiveness. The deployment of strategic frameworks (PESTLE, Porter's Five Forces and SWOT) meant the translation of unstructured data into systematic analysis and the identification of the main sources of competitive advantage and threat.

Consultancy and problem-solving skills: The setting of the problem here referred to the multidimensional character of sustainability and supply-chain transparency. The evaluation of stakeholder expectations and possible conflicts indicated the necessity of managing the conflicting interests. The formulation of evidence-based recommendations reinforced the elements of strategic thinking and actionable solutions to achieve strategic alignment of organisational goals and the ethical considerations (Adepoju et al., 2023). The exercise highlighted the importance of having clear goals, evidence-based arguments and implementation strategies in working with clients.

Communication skills: Using a developed structure of a 4,800-word consultancy report enhanced writing ability by necessitating the expression of unclear information succinctly, as well as logical clarity. The inclusion of citations through appropriate referencing created academic rigour and credibility. Breaking down technical sustainability information to non-expert audiences helped to underline the importance of customising messages to key stakeholders, including executives, investors and consumers.

Ethical awareness and professional judgement: Researching labour rights claims and evaluation of corporate policies enhanced knowledge of ethical issues in global supply chains. The project demonstrated the vulnerability of voluntary codes of conduct in defending the workers and the significance of binding agreements and multi-stakeholder alliances (Frishling, 2024). The ability to reflect on the impact of corporate activity on vulnerable employees led to empathy and a subsequent desire to act responsibly in business.

Industry expertise and flexibility: The study of the changing trends in the sportswear industry, including the shift towards using eco-friendly materials, digital traceability and new market prospects, created sector-specific knowledge. Knowing the effect of macroeconomic phenomena and regulatory transformations on corporate strategy will equip me to advise companies undergoing similar stresses. The project highlighted how important it is to keep up with changes in ESG and align advice.

Personal growth: Handling a large research project in a described framework promoted project management abilities like planning, time management, and attention to detail. The practise added confidence in engaging with complex sustainability problems and enhanced preparedness to work as a consultant, sustainability manager or corporate strategist (Hasan, 2024). On the whole, the project expanded professional skills and offered practical expertise in applying high-quality, evidence-based recommendations to assist in business performance and positive social impact.

Further learning: Technical literacy, such as the ability to work with spreadsheet analysis, data visualisation and reporting software, has been enhanced through extensive use of digital tools and large data volumes. Cross-cultural research on labour behaviour in various areas increased cultural awareness and sensitivity to local behaviours, which is a vital skill when organising advice to international businesses. Explain complex sustainability problems to various audiences, including academics and industry practitioners, reinforced compelling communication and leadership, and emphasised the relevance of messaging to different stakeholder groups.

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